

iLovePDF’s iOS advantage, and where Smallpdf is weakest

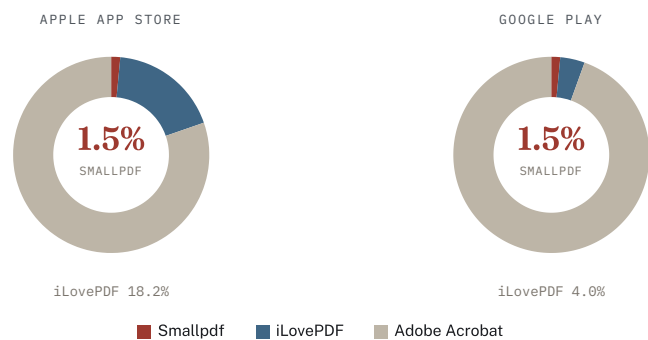
Two things the public App Store and Google Play data show, September 2026.

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I thought I would show you some insights I found about your company. Nothing here is inside information. It is all public store data, pulled in an afternoon, but a few things in it surprised me and I thought they were worth passing on.

Smallpdf, iLovePDF and Adobe Acrobat are the three largest PDF tools on both mobile stores. Ratings and reviews are a rough proxy for reach, and splitting them three ways gives a like-for-like picture within each store.

SHARE OF RATINGS AMONG THE THREE LARGEST PDF APPS



App Store: ratings on file across 25 storefronts. Google Play: review counts, which Google publishes globally rather than by country. Downloads tell the same story more coarsely, in buckets: Smallpdf 5M+, iLovePDF 10M+, Adobe 500M+.

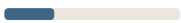
Smallpdf’s position is the same on both stores. iLovePDF’s is not. Smallpdf holds 1.5% of the three on the App Store and 1.5% on Google Play. iLovePDF holds 18.2% on the App Store and 4.0% on Google Play, so it is roughly four times stronger on iOS than on Android while Smallpdf and Adobe are not. Whatever iLovePDF is doing on iOS, it is specific to iOS, and it is worth knowing what it is.

What these numbers are not. Apple publishes ratings, Google publishes reviews, and the two are different acts. The shares are internally consistent within each store, which is what makes the comparison usable, but the absolute figures are not interchangeable across stores. Neither store publishes usage, and Smallpdf’s own data puts 61% of its sessions on desktop, so all of this describes the mobile surface rather than the business.

APPLE APP STORE, BY MARKET

Ratings on file per storefront, September 2026. Ordered by Smallpdf’s share. Romance-language markets are shown in red and bold.

MARKET	SMALLPDF	ILOVEPDF	SHARE	SMALLPDF ★	ILOVEPDF ★
Türkiye	1,827	5,471	33.4%	4.88	4.79
Germany	2,179	7,308	29.8%	4.83	4.76
Netherlands	300	1,011	29.7%	4.87	4.69
Austria	159	578	27.5%	4.81	4.72
Sweden	126	580	21.7%	4.81	4.74
Switzerland	337	1,839	18.3%	4.86	4.81
Indonesia	3,231	20,529	15.7%	4.90	4.89
Philippines	653	4,239	15.4%	4.84	4.84
United States	6,878	51,494	13.4%	4.84	4.76
United Kingdom	873	6,934	12.6%	4.82	4.83
India	4,068	33,123	12.3%	4.85	4.72

MARKET	SMALLPDF	ILOVEPDF	SHARE	SMALLPDF ★	ILOVEPDF ★
Australia	524	4,934	10.6% 	4.79	4.84
Poland	205	1,939	10.6% 	4.81	4.84
Belgium	177	1,791	9.9% 	4.88	4.75
Canada	804	9,423	8.5% 	4.82	4.85
Italy	1,572	22,470	7.0% 	4.86	4.81
France	1,696	28,922	5.9% 	4.85	4.79
Portugal	225	3,946	5.7% 	4.83	4.83
Brazil	4,811	90,304	5.3% 	4.92	4.93
UAE	591	11,502	5.1% 	4.84	4.76
Japan	908	18,036	5.0% 	4.79	4.71
South Africa	439	10,527	4.2% 	4.87	4.81
Mexico	2,282	62,218	3.7% 	4.87	4.90
Spain	760	25,136	3.0% 	4.84	4.82
Argentina	361	12,236	3.0% 	4.89	4.90
All 25	35,986	436,490	8.2%		

WHAT THE SPREAD SHOWS, AND WHAT IT DOES NOT

- **The range is nearly elevenfold**, from 33.4% in Türkiye and 29.8% in Germany down to 3.0% in Spain and Argentina. An 8.2% average describes none of these markets.
- **It is not a quality gap.** Both apps score between 4.7 and 4.9 in every market, usually within a few hundredths of each other. Users who install Smallpdf rate it as highly as users who install iLovePDF, wherever they are.
- **It is not a localisation gap.** Smallpdf ships 23 languages and iLovePDF 24, and both include Spanish, French, Italian and Portuguese. The only differences are Bulgarian, Catalan and Greek on one side and Danish and Norwegian on the other.
- **All seven Romance-language markets fall in the bottom ten.** Argentina and Spain are the lowest two. iLovePDF was founded in Barcelona in 2010, Smallpdf in Zurich in 2013, and if roughly two thirds of growth comes from organic search then position is won separately in each language, where a three-year head start compounds. Translation puts the product in a language; it does not transfer search authority.

Stated as a hypothesis, because that is what it is. I sorted the markets, saw the cluster, and drew the grouping around it afterwards. A permutation test says a clustering this low would arise by chance in about 4 of 10,000 random picks of seven countries, but a test chosen after seeing the data is not independent evidence. The converse does not hold either: Türkiye is the strongest market of all and has nothing to do with the pattern, and Japan, South Africa and the UAE are weak without being Romance-language. Confirming or discarding this needs data I cannot see.

GOOGLE PLAY, BY MARKET

Google publishes review counts and downloads globally but localises the star rating, so Play can test satisfaction by market though not reach. Ordered by Smallpdf's deficit.

MARKET	SMALLPDF	ILOVEPDF	DIFFERENCE
Germany	4.2	4.5	-0.3
Canada	4.3	4.6	-0.3
Spain	4.5	4.7	-0.2
Argentina	4.6	4.8	-0.2
Australia	4.4	4.6	-0.2
Poland	4.4	4.6	-0.2
Italy	4.6	4.7	-0.1
Austria	4.5	4.6	-0.1
Philippines	4.7	4.8	-0.1
United States	4.5	4.6	-0.1
UAE	4.7	4.8	-0.1
Mexico	4.7	4.8	-0.1
Türkiye	4.5	4.5	+0.0

MARKET	SMALLPDF	ILOVEPDF	DIFFERENCE
Netherlands	4.4	4.4	+0.0
Switzerland	4.6	4.6	+0.0
United Kingdom	4.6	4.6	+0.0
India	4.6	4.6	+0.0
Brazil	4.8	4.8	+0.0
South Africa	4.8	4.8	+0.0
Portugal	4.8	4.7	+0.1
Japan	4.6	4.5	+0.1
Indonesia	4.9	4.8	+0.1
France	4.7	4.6	+0.1
Sweden	4.7	4.5	+0.2
Belgium	4.7	4.5	+0.2

This is the out-of-sample test, and it half worked. Play cannot test the reach pattern, because the counts are global. It can test satisfaction, and there the finding holds in a second independent dataset: Smallpdf averages 0.048 below iLovePDF across 25 markets, and in Romance-language markets specifically 0.057, which is the same number. Satisfaction is flat everywhere on both platforms. So the language pattern on iOS remains untested, and the claim that the gap is about distribution rather than product is now supported twice.

ONE ODDITY WORTH A QUESTION

Germany is Smallpdf's weakest rating on Play, 4.2 against 4.5, while being its second strongest market on iOS and one of the four markets its own published statistics name as strongest. Large presence and lower satisfaction in the same market is the kind of tension that usually has a specific cause behind it.

METHOD, AND WHAT WOULD UNDERMINE THIS

- App Store figures come from Apple's public lookup API, one call per storefront, 25 storefronts, September 2026. Play figures come from the public store pages with the country parameter set.
- Ratings counts are a cumulative stock, not current users and not momentum. An app that was strong three years ago and is fading now still looks strong here.
- Ratings counts depend on how hard an app prompts for them. If iLovePDF prompts more often, its counts inflate independently of install base. That would apply uniformly across countries, so it cannot explain the spread, but it can inflate the level.
- Smallpdf is web-first. Its own published data puts 61% of sessions on desktop. Everything here measures the mobile surface, which is 39% and growing fastest, not the business.
- Comparable public data on web share is paywalled. Where Similarweb does show a head-to-head figure, for India, it puts Smallpdf at 13.27% of the two sites' combined traffic; the App Store ratio for India is about 11%. Two unrelated datasets, two points apart.

All of this is assembled from outside, from data anyone can pull. The value of it is the questions it raises, not the answers, and every one of them could be settled in a single query by someone with access to the real numbers.